

Delaware County Budget Hearings September 7th 2023

Segment #2

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rYQsV5dmdX8
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Target Category	delaware_county

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Comprehensive Municipal Meeting Summary & Report

1. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The presiding officer called the meeting back to order following a lunch recess [00:13:21](#). The board proceeded directly into departmental budget reviews and work sessions for the upcoming fiscal year.
- **Attendance:** Specific roll call was not verbally conducted at the resumption of the meeting; however, active board participants, municipal leaders, and department heads included:
 - Presiding Officer / Council President
 - Board Members / Councilmembers (including referenced members: Ryan, Eugene, Bill, Jessica)
 - Department Heads and Elected Officials: Fred (911/Dispatch), Kyle (GIS), Megan, Steve (Jail/Sheriff), Kelly (Public Defender), and Angie (Engineer).

2. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** None recorded in this segment of the transcript (resumed directly from lunch recess).

- **Approval of Minutes:** Not discussed during this session.
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3. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:13:21 Extension Office Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Extension Office representative.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The department reported on its 2023 operating budget and identified unspent funds that could be returned to assist the county. The office offered a total voluntary give-back of \$2,050 (\$1,300 from office supplies and \$750 from travel) for the current 2023 budget year, noting that this represents a significant percentage of their small budget. Their 2024 budget request was maintained as originally submitted.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Acknowledged with appreciation by the board; no formal vote taken during this work session review.
- **00:14:54 Fair Board Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board / Staff.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** It was noted that this budget falls outside County General and outside the maximum levy. The board reviewed the 2024 budget request.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Recommended and accepted as presented by consensus.
- **00:16:18 GIS Department Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Kyle (00:16:18 Page 29).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The department reviewed line items, noting that requests outside of salaries were minimal (primarily travel/level 323 lines).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Accepted by consensus.
- **00:17:11 Emergency Management Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Department Representative (00:17:11 Page 41).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussed salary adjustments and a line-item reallocation moving funds out of printing (\$1,000) and into a newly established uniform line item, keeping the overall 2023 total baseline of \$77,043 intact.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Accepted by consensus.
- **00:20:41 EMS Budget & Fair Board / Health Note**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** EMS Department / Tanya (00:20:43 Page 45).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The EMS department offered 2023 current budget give-backs across several line items totaling \$3,025. Discussion ensued regarding rolling back 2024 requests to 2023 salary and line-item baselines, handling paramedic-to-advanced EMT reclassifications for staff in school, utility cost stabilization (gas prices dropping), uniform budget reductions from \$10,000 to \$8,000, and adjustments to ambulance billing lines.
 - *New Revenue Notification:* The department reported an unexpected retroactive Medicare/Medicaid reimbursement windfall of \$42,991.88 from 2021 claims

received from the state. Extensive debate occurred regarding budget tightness, historical spending rates, and maintaining operational reserves.

- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Reviewed line by line; adjustments noted for auditor recalculation.
- **01:12:21 Communications Center / 911 Dispatch Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Fred ([01:12:21](#) Page 3).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Director Fred presented a detailed defense of the 911 Dispatch budget, emphasizing that the department operates under a 5-year interlocal agreement with the City of Muncie, which contributes significant funding (\$1.025 million) specifically designated to elevate dispatch capabilities and staff retention, rather than subsidizing general county funds. The department generates approximately \$1.8 million in total revenue offsets.
 - Debate focused on whether to force the dispatch budget back to 2023 baseline numbers versus funding proposed staff raises (structured at \$3,000/employee, later discussed at \$2,000). The director noted mandatory baseline fixed costs (FICA, PERF, health insurance, educational incentives) cannot be cut without risking staff retention and violating service metrics under the interlocal agreement.
 - Board members and the director negotiated reductions in training, telephone backups, and equipment lines, while acknowledging the severe staffing turnaround achieved over the past year.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Extensive line-by-line revisions logged for auditor adjustment; no final binding vote taken pending grand-total recalculations.
- **02:27:18 Sheriff's Department & Jail Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sheriff Steve ([02:27:18](#) Page 12 / Page 32).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Sheriff Steve advocated strongly for public safety budgeting, emphasizing the 24/7 nature of jail operations, rising food and medical contract costs, and ongoing revenue generation by housing out-of-county inmates (over \$300,000 brought in year-to-date).
 - *Pension Funding Options:* The board reviewed options for the Sheriff's retirement pension, debating between the highest request ("Cadillac" plan at \$1,798,000) and lower baseline options ("Chevy" plan at \$1,389,218), alongside contributions from the County Council Public Safety LIT (Local Income Tax) fund.
 - *Jail Operations:* Discussed clothing allowances (50-72 eligible personnel), medical contracts (\$679,000), food costs, institutional/cleaning supplies, and the conversion of a long-term part-time maintenance worker (7 years of service) into a full-time position to properly oversee facility maintenance across shifts.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Line items adjusted to 2023 baselines where applicable; pension funding and LIT contributions balanced to achieve major structural reductions.
- **03:56:51 Public Defender Budget Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Kelly ([03:56:51](#)).

- **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed compliance requirements to maintain 40% state reimbursement for public defender salaries. Discussed pay parity for non-lawyer support staff, administrative assistant salary adjustments (raising the base floor to \$30,000), legal secretary reclassifications, and a rare request to replace an aging computer (8 years old) using general funds. The office anticipates state reimbursements between \$700,000 and \$725,000 for the next year.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Salary compliance lines adjusted; computer replacement approved; reviewed by consensus.
- **04:38:30 Commissioners & County General / Miscellaneous Budgets**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board of Commissioners / Pam / Staff (04:38:30 Page 42).
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - *Liability Insurance (Line 342):* Addressed a major under-budgeted discrepancy. Brokers indicated potential premium increases of 5 to 8 percent. The board evaluated the financial impact and discussed worst-case funding scenarios.
 - *Give-backs:* Noted 2023 current-year give-backs from commissioners, including \$25,000 from unemployment and \$10,000 from postage.
 - *Institutional / Developmental Disabilities Care:* Reviewed state-mandated accounts (Line 386), noting recent mid-year appropriations of \$250,000 and ongoing high-utilization trends for pre-trial release and institutional care programs.
 - *External Agencies:* Discussed funding requests for Soil and Water Conservation (allocated \$25,000 for initial consideration despite historical zero-funding), animal shelter, and juvenile detention/YOC contracts (\$673,152).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Extensive reductions and adjustments recorded for subsequent recalculation.
- **05:47:32 County Engineer, Highway, and Infrastructure Funds Review**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Angie (05:47:32 Page 57).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Reviewed engineering, Cumulative Bridge (Cum Bridge), Motor Vehicle Highway (MVH), and Local Roads and Streets (LRS) funds. Addressed questions regarding maximum levy impacts on rate-driven funds like Cum Bridge, noting that unspent balances accumulate to fund capital projects (such as bridges) without incurring debt. Agreed to have engineering staff review line items to shave off requested differences (\$8,651 for engineering; \$35,869 for Cum Bridge) to align with 2023 baselines.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Department heads tasked with fine-tuning line items overnight for review the following morning.

4. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- *Note:* No general citizen forum or open public comment period from members of the general public occurred during this transcribed work session; discussion was strictly limited to the board, elected officials, and municipal department heads regarding budget line items.
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5. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - The meeting recessed with a cumulative running deficit/excess over the 2023 budget standing at approximately **\$1.722 million** over baseline, requiring continued trimming.
 - The auditor's office was assigned the task of running updated FICA, PERF, and health insurance figures overnight.
 - **Adjournment:**
 - The presiding officer announced that the board will reconvene the budget work sessions the following morning at **8:30 AM** to address remaining departmental budgets before setting a date for subsequent public hearings and final adoption.
 - Meeting recessed / adjourned for the evening **06:09:23**.
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